



Africa's paddy fields

GROWING RICE IN MADAGASCAR

STRIKING BAOBAB TREES TOWER OVER PADDY FIELDS edged with water hyacinths on the west coast of Madagascar. Rice is the staple food of the island, and is grown on every available piece of land. Ironically, its very cultivation is contributing to a food shortage. Madagascar has always suffered from soil erosion, but the clearing of 80 percent of its forests to provide farmland has accelerated this process. Sadly, the exquisite water hyacinths make matters worse. Choking up rivers and lakes all over Africa, these weeds are responsible for killing fish and smothering crops. They are just another obstacle to Malagasy farmers trying to produce enough food for the islanders.

